new nickname, with fourth-form connotations. I am now known to all and sundry as ‘Sac’ …

I didn’t realize that I was the first active English cricketer to be knighted, but, as mentioned in the previous chapter, identification with icons is daunting. It took Alec Bedser forty years to be so honoured. The other players – Hobbs, Hutton, Cowdrey and Botham – are part of a bloodline that some see as sacred. That’s hard to get your head round.

As a sportsman you become accustomed to excessive praise and unwarranted criticism from perfect strangers. That’s part of the job. This was my chance to share my good fortune with friends and family. Alice used a special WhatsApp group to organize open house on New Year’s Day. It was a special celebration, one of those memories that will last a lifetime.

By then the knighthood was public knowledge. We made an appreciable dent in the thirty-three specially labelled bottles of champagne, one for each Test hundred, presented to me by the England boys. The investiture itself, on 26 February, was surreal. Everyone has a quiet terror at offending protocol. I knelt, head bowed, with my right knee on a crimson silk-velvet stool, as the sword, which belonged to George VI, lightly touched my right and then my left shoulder.

Sorry to shatter any illusions, but Her Majesty does not say ‘Arise, Sir Alastair …’

The Queen was serene, and impeccably informed. She congratulated me before commenting on the excellence of the West Indies bowlers in the recent Test series and asked how lambing was going on the farm. I appreciate people have differing views on the validity of the honours system, but for me it was a deeply affecting moment.

Following afternoon tea at the Ritz, the extended family returned to reality. It was a time of personal reflection, since I found myself at an intersection of my life. I still had cricket, in the form of a three-year contract with Essex, but the emphasis had shifted.

Another paragraph from Athers’s article struck a chord: ‘In time, he will surely recognize that his greatest achievement was not the gift from some mandarin at Whitehall, but the knowledge that when tested time and again he was not found wanting. The rest is an adornment. That day in September, when the ground stood and drowned him in wave after wave of adulation, will give him a more lasting inner glow than will any reflection from a shiny bauble. That memory will last a lifetime.’